



» TOURNAMENT WRAP

THE LONG RETURN

After more than half a century of frustration, rebuilds, near-misses, and shifting identities, New York Knicks is finally back at the **summit of the NBA.**

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The birthplace of the National Basketball Association. The largest basketball market, in terms of both metro population and TV market size, in the U.S. The most valuable franchise in the NBA, playing out of what most aficionados of the sport call an iconic venue, Madison Square Garden. These are the facts that characterise the Big Apple and its beloved basketball team, the New York Knicks.

Yet it took the Knicks, originally called the Knickerbockers, 53 years since their second championship in 1973 to finally climb back to the apex of the NBA. They managed it by defeating the San Antonio Spurs 4-1 in a series far more closely fought than the scoreline suggests.

The championship win rounded off an astounding post-season run by the Knicks. After falling behind 2-1 to the Atlanta Hawks in the first round, dropping two consecutive games by a single point each, they reeled off a searing 13-game winning streak, the

second-longest in a single post-season in NBA history, which included beating the Spurs twice in San Antonio to open the Finals. By the time the playoffs finished, the New York Knicks had a 14.9-point differential — the average difference between the Knicks' and their opponents' scorelines — the best such mark in NBA playoff history.

Yet no one would have predicted this success at the beginning of the season. The Knicks were not thoroughgoing favourites to win the title in October 2025. That honour belonged to the Oklahoma City Thunder, the defending champion, who continued its march from the previous season by topping the